The Eurasian challenge

The relative weaknesses of the Russian economy – all the elements that threaten Moscow's global projection and cast a shadow on the prosperity of the Russian state and its people – are, paradoxically, entirely coherent with the rise of Russia as the most direct contender with US imperialism today. A merely quantitative approach to international rivalry will usually overlook the accumulation and class dynamics behind this contemporary form. This is an important point, particularly since much of the literature considering Russia's emerging power status generally maps the relative strength of the Russian economy directly onto its international assertiveness. Such an analytical strategy might make considerable sense at first sight, but it can also prove misleading. S Neil Macfarlane, for instance, argued that Russia's problems led it to pursue a 'mixed approach of partnership or acquiescence on matters of vital interest to the hegemonic power, and more competitive behaviour on issues deemed central to Russia but peripheral to US interests' (2006:42).

The conflict over Ukraine offers a comprehensive refutation of this point: here is an obvious 'issue' (an area of economic and strategic overlapping interests), which, because it is deemed central by both Russia and Western imperialism, can easily morph into a major security conundrum and a geopolitical fault line, quite regardless of the relative balance of strength between any of the contenders. A similar argument would apply for those who, in view of Russia's troubles after 2009, identified a wholesale downscaling in Moscow's foreign policy, and a more sober attempt to build a low-cost sphere of influence, and look for a 'lily-pad empire' (after Donald Rumsfeld's 'lily-pad army' concept): 'In its version of a "lily-pad" empire, Russia seeks to get the benefits while minimising the costs. As one Russian expert says: "We would like to choose the best bits of the CIS" – that is, energy infrastructure, key sectors of the economy and the right to station our military bases abroad – "and leave the rest to go to hell"' (Judah, Kobzova and Popescu 2011:28).

The confluence of state and business interests in pursuing precisely this kind of expansionism (avoiding longer-term investment and development in the Russian economy, and seeking energy and other economic assets abroad) is something we've already examined. Additionally, Russia maintains more than 30 000 military personnel in its 'near abroad' and has also obtained majority stakes in the gas transit systems particularly in Armenia and Moldova, while pushing hard to make gains in Ukraine (Naftogaz as the prize), Belarus and even Eastern Europe.[2] The lily-pad thesis, therefore, is questionable: there is no obvious monetary benefit for Russia in singlehandedly sustaining South Ossetia,